

Jason, Medea, and the Argonauts

And now is all that ancient story told
Of him who won the guarded fleece of gold.

—WILLIAM MORRIS, *The Life and Death of Jason*



The Minyae

The saga of the Argonauts covers much of the Greek world in its geographical scope and includes many of the leading Greek heroes of the age before the Trojan War. The crew of the **Argo** included the flower of Greece, descendants of gods and ancestors of Greek nobles. They are often referred to as **Minyae**, and among cities that claimed Minyan descent were **Iolcus** in Thessaly and Miletus in Ionia. Jason belonged to the ruling family of Iolcus, and the Euxine Sea (i.e., the Black Sea), where the main part of the saga takes place, was an area particularly colonized by the Milesians.

The name *Minyae* therefore tells us something about the origin of the saga. Homer calls the *Argo* “all men’s concern,” reflecting the adventures of the seamen of Mycenaean Greece. Later additions reflect the expansion of the Greeks into the Black Sea area from the eighth century onward. Folktale elements can be seen in the name **Aea** (which means no more than “land”) that Homer uses for the country to which the *Argo* sailed, and its king, **Aeëtes** (Man of the Land). It is a mysterious land on the edge of the world, a suitable setting for a story in which magic and miracle play a big part. The folktale element can further be

distinguished in the formal outline of the legend, where a hero is set a number of impossible tasks that he performs unscathed, helped by the local princess, whom he then marries.¹

Jason and the Golden Fleece

The saga concerns the quest for the Golden Fleece by Jason and the crew of the *Argo*. The Boeotian king **Athamas** took as his first wife **Nephele**, whose name means “cloud.” After bearing Athamas two children, **Phrixus** and **Helle**, she returned to the sky. Athamas then married **Ino**, one of the daughters of Cadmus, who attempted to destroy her stepchildren. She also persuaded the Boeotian women to parch the seed grain so that when it was sown nothing grew. In the ensuing famine, Athamas sent to Delphi for advice, but Ino suborned the envoys to report that the god advised Athamas to sacrifice Phrixus if he wanted the famine to end. As he was about to perform the sacrifice, Nephele snatched Phrixus and Helle up into the sky and set them on a golden-fleeced ram that Hermes had given her. The ram carried them eastward through the heavens. Above the straits between Europe and Asia (the **Dardanelles**), Helle fell off and drowned, and the straits were called the

Hellespont after her. Phrixus continued his flight and came to Colchis, at the eastern end of the Black Sea, where King Aeëtes (son of Helius and brother of Circe and Pasiphaë) received him with kindness and gave him his elder daughter, Chalciope, as wife. Phrixus sacrificed the ram to Zeus Phyxius (i.e., Zeus as god of escape) and gave the Golden Fleece to Aeëtes, who hung it up on an oak tree in a grove sacred to Ares, where it was guarded by a never-sleeping serpent. Phrixus himself lived on at Colchis, where he finally died; his four sons by Chalciope—Argus, Melas, Phrontis, and Cytisorus—play a minor part in the Argonauts’ saga. The fleece, a golden treasure guarded by a dragon, became a goal for a hero’s quest.



The Building of the Argo.

Terra-cotta relief from Campania, mid-first century A.D. Athena sits on the left; her shield rests against her stool, while her owl perches on a column behind her. She helps a workman (or possibly an Argonaut) place a sail on the yard-arm. To the right Argus works on the stern with a hammer and chisel. In the background is a city wall with a closed gate and a tree. (© Marie-Lan Nguyen/Wikimedia Commons)

Cretheus, brother of Athamas, was king of Iolcus. At his death, his stepson Pelias (son of Poseidon and Tyro, wife of Cretheus) usurped the throne and deposed the rightful heir, **Aeson**, son of Cretheus and Tyro and father of Jason. Jason’s mother, Polymede,² sent the boy away to the hills to be educated by the centaur **Chiron** and cared for by Chiron’s mother, Philyra. After twenty years, Jason returned to Iolcus to claim the throne that rightly belonged to his family. Pelias knew that he was fated to be killed by a descendant of Aeolus, and the Delphic oracle had warned him to “beware of the man with one sandal.” He realized his fate was approaching when Jason appeared wearing one sandal.

On the way down from the hills, Jason had carried an old woman across the river Anaurus in full spate, losing one sandal as he tried to get a foothold in the mud. The old woman was the goddess **Hera**, who thereafter favored him, just as she remained hostile to Pelias, who had neglected to sacrifice to

her. Pelias promised to yield the throne as soon as Jason brought him the Golden Fleece, which Phrixus, appearing to him in a dream, had ordered him to obtain. Whether for this reason or for some other, Jason readily undertook the task.

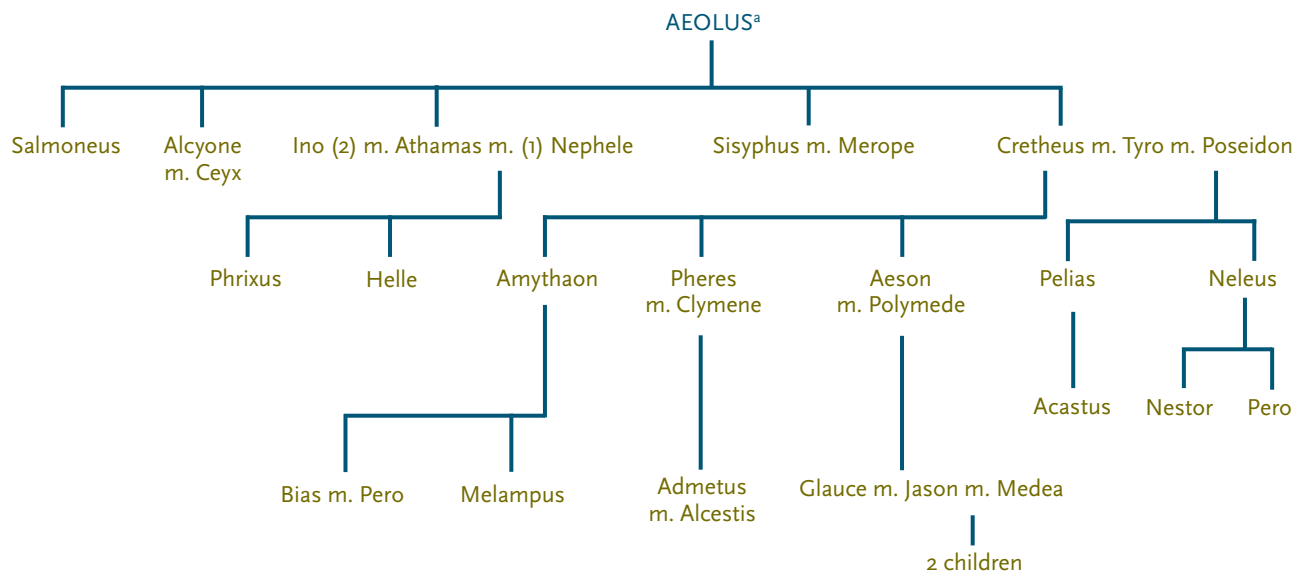
The Argonauts

In preparation for the expedition, the *Argo* was built, “which . . . first through the Euxine seas bore all the flower of Greece” (Spenser, *Faerie Queen* 2. 12. 44). Its name means “swift,” and it was built by Argus, son of Arestor, with the help of Athena. In its bows Athena put a piece of wood made from an oak of Dodona (where there was an oracle of Zeus), which had the power of speech.

The crew came from all over Greece, motivated by the heroic quality of *arete* (Pindar, *Pythian Odes* 4. 184–187):

Hera kindled all-persuading sweet desire in the sons of gods for the ship *Argo*, so that none should be left behind to nurse a life without danger at his mother’s side, but rather that he should find even against death the fairest antidote in his own courage along with others of his age.

Lists of the names of the Argonauts vary, since the Greeks of later ages were eager to claim an Argonaut for an ancestor. Two heroes who figure prominently in all the lists, **Orpheus** and **Heracles**, have no place in the original story. Orpheus is a post-Homeric figure, and Heracles, as the most important of the Greek heroes, could hardly be left out of a saga that occurred in his own lifetime. He



^aThis Aeolus was the son of Hellen and is to be distinguished from Aeolus, the king of the winds.

Figure 24.1. The Ancestry of Jason



The Voyage of the *Argo* to Colchis. Jason's voyage to Colchis is simpler to trace geographically. The return voyage to Iolcus is confused and takes the Argonauts around Italy in the north to Libya on the coast of North Africa.

To explore an interactive version of this map, please go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

refused to accept the leadership, in favor of Jason, and he disappeared from the expedition before the *Argo* had even reached the Black Sea.

Of the fifty or so names included among the Argonauts, certain groups stand out. These are the heroes from Thessaly, such as Jason, and those from the Peloponnese, such as Augeas, king of Elis; a third group consists of Meleager and other heroes who took part in the Calydonian boar hunt; a fourth includes the parents of Trojan War heroes, such as Peleus (father of Achilles), Telamon (father of Ajax Telamonius), Oileus (father of Ajax the Less), and Nauplius (father of Palamedes).

Some of the Argonauts had special gifts. These were the seers Idmon and Mopsus; Castor and Polydeuces, excellent as horseman and boxer, respectively, with their later enemies, Idas and Lynceus, the latter of whom had such keen sight that he could see even beneath the earth; Periclymenus, son of Neleus, who

could take whatever shape he liked in battle (this was Poseidon's gift); Euphemus, son of Poseidon, who could run so fast over the waves of the sea that his feet stayed dry; Zetes and Calaïs, the winged sons of Boreas; Argus, the skilled shipwright; and finally, the helmsman, Tiphys. Of these, only Polydeuces, Zetes, Calaïs, Argus, and Tiphys have any significant part in the legend as we now have it. Originally, the individual Argonauts must have used their gifts to help Jason perform his otherwise impossible tasks.

The Voyage to Colchis

Hypsipyle and the Lemnian Women

After leaving Iolcus, the Argonauts sailed to the island of Lemnos, where they found only women, led by their queen, Hypsipyle. Aphrodite had punished them for neglecting her worship and had made them unattractive to their husbands. The men therefore had taken Thracian concubines whom they had captured in war. In revenge, the Lemnian women murdered every male on the island, with the exception of the king, **Thoas**, who was son of Dionysus and father of Hypsipyle. Hypsipyle first hid Thoas in the temple of Dionysus and then put him in a chest in which he floated to the land of the Tauri (i.e., southern Russia) and there became a priest of Artemis. Meanwhile, the Lemnian women received the Argonauts, who stayed on the island for a year. Among the many children born as a result of their stay were the twin sons of Jason and Hypsipyle, Euneos and Thoas (or Nebrophonus). After Jason's departure, Hypsipyle's deception in saving her father Thoas was discovered, and she was driven from the island. Eventually, she was captured by pirates and sold into slavery, becoming the servant of Lycurgus, king of Nemea.

In Greece, Hypsipyle became the nurse of the child of Lycurgus, **Opheltes**. Euripides presented this part of Hypsipyle's story in the tragedy *Hypsipyle* (see p. 426). She was eventually brought back to Lemnos by her sons. As a mythological figure, Hypsipyle is significant because she was the queen of a society from which males have been driven out and also because of her connection with the founding of the Nemean Games in honor of Opheltes. The Roman epic poet Statius devoted a long episode of his *Thebaid* to her story, as did his contemporary Valerius Flaccus, in his epic *Argonautica*. Ovid made her a romantically deserted heroine in his *Heroides*.

Cyzicus and Cios

After touching at Samothrace, where they were initiated into the mysteries, the Argonauts sailed on to the Propontis and put in at Cyzicus, where the Doliones lived under King Cyzicus, who received them well. In return for this hospitality, Heracles killed the earthborn giants who lived nearby. The Argonauts were driven back to Cyzicus by contrary winds, and in a night battle (for the Doliones took them for night raiders) they killed the king. The next day they helped bury Cyzicus before sailing off again.

Their next port of call was Cios, farther eastward along the Asiatic shore of the Propontis, where they landed so that **Heracles** could replace his broken oar. Here **Hylas** was lost and Heracles left the expedition (see p. 567).

Amycus

Next, the Argonauts passed into the Euxine (the Black Sea) and came to the land of the Bebryces, a Bithynian tribe whose custom was to compel strangers to box with their king, Amycus, a son of Poseidon, who had never lost a boxing match. **Polydeuces** fought Amycus and killed him.

Phineus and the Harpies and the Symplegades

Next they came to Salmydessus on the Euxine shore of Thrace, where they were received by King Phineus, a blind prophet.³ Phineas was tormented by the Harpies, two winged monsters (their name means “**the snatchers**”) who, every time a meal was set before him, swooped down upon it, snatched away most of the food, and fouled the rest. When the Harpies next appeared, **Zetes** and **Calais**, the winged sons of Boreas, pursued them with drawn swords to the Strophades Islands, where Iris put an end to the chase by making the sons of Boreas return and the Harpies swear never to go near Phineus again. Phineus foretold the rest of the voyage to the Argonauts and forewarned them of its dangers. He told them of the Symplegades (Clashing Rocks), two huge rocks near the western end of the Black Sea that clashed together driven by the force of the winds. Nothing had ever yet passed between them, and it was fated that they should remain fixed once a ship had made the passage. Phineus advised the Argonauts to release a dove, and if it succeeded in flying between the rocks, then they themselves were to row hard between them as they recoiled. If it failed, they were to turn back. In the event the dove was successful, and the Argonauts, with the help of Athena (or Hera), got through before the rocks clashed for the last time, losing part of the ship’s stern ornament. The Symplegades remained fixed, never to threaten seafarers again.⁴

The Voyage through the Euxine Sea

Not far along the Asiatic coast of the Euxine lived the Mariandyni, whose king, Lycus, received the Argonauts hospitably. Here Idmon was killed by a boar, and the helmsman, Tiphys, died. Nevertheless, with the Arcadian hero Ancaeus, son of Lycurgus, as the new helmsman, they sailed on past the land of the Amazons and that of the iron-working Chalybes and came to the Island of Ares, where the Stymphalian Birds (frightened away from Greece by Heracles in his sixth Labor) now lived. These they kept at bay by clashing their shields together. Here they also found Phrixus’ four sons, shipwrecked during an attempted voyage from Colchis to Boeotia. They took them on board the *Argo* and found them of no little help when they reached Colchis. Finally, they sailed up the river Phasis to Colchis.

Jason at Colchis

At Colchis, Aeëtes was prepared to let Jason take the fleece only if he first performed a series of impossible tasks. These were to yoke a pair of brazen-footed, fire-breathing bulls, the gift of Hephaestus to Aeëtes, and with them plow a large



Jason Is Disgorged by the Dragon That Guards the Golden Fleece. Athenian red-figure cup by Douris, ca. 470 B.C.; diameter 11 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. Athena (not Medea) watches the bearded dragon disgorge Jason. She holds an owl and wears the aegis. The fleece hangs on the tree in the background. There are no literary sources for this version of the myth. (Alinari/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

field and sow it with dragon's teeth, from which would spring up armed men, whom he would then have to kill.⁵

Medea

Medea, Aeëtes' younger daughter, now enters the saga and brings to it elements of magic and folktale. Through the agency of Hera and Aphrodite, she fell in love with Jason and agreed to help him at the request of Chalciope, mother of Argus (who had returned to Colchis with the Argonauts). She was herself priestess of **Hecate**, as skilled in magic as her aunt **Circe**. She gave Jason a magic ointment that would protect him from harm by fire or iron for the space of a day. So he plowed the field with the fire-breathing bulls, and he threw a stone among the armed men who sprang from the dragon's teeth to set them fighting one another. Then he took the fleece, with Medea's help, drugging the serpent with herbs that she had provided.

Euripides, however, in his tragedy *Medea*, gives Medea a larger part in performing the tasks and gaining the fleece. She, rather than Jason, is the dragon-slayer, as she reminds Jason (*Medea* 476–482):

I saved you, as all the Greeks know who embarked with you on the ship *Argo*, when you were sent to master the fire-breathing bulls with yokes and sow the death-bringing field. I killed the serpent, which unsleeping guarded the golden fleece, twining its many coils around it, and I brought you the light of salvation.

In the red-figure cup above, Jason's part is even less heroic, as he hangs limply from the jaws of the serpent while Athena (not Medea) stands before him.

Ovid's Narrative

Ovid's account restores Jason's heroic stature. His narrative begins the day after Medea's meeting with Jason at the shrine of Hecate (*Metamorphoses* 7. 100–158):



Audio

The next dawn had put to flight the gleaming stars when the people assembled in Mars' sacred field and took their place on the higher ground. The king himself sat enthroned among his army, conspicuous by his purple robe and

Jason Takes the Golden Fleece, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on panel, 1636, 10 ½ × 11 ¼ in. Jason jauntily passes by the statue of Mars [Ares], with the fleece draped over his left arm. He is dressed as a Roman soldier. Rubens follows the narrative of Hyginus, who said that Phrixus dedicated the fleece in the temple of Mars, rather than the narrative given here. Note the absence of Medea or Athena as Jason's helpers. (*Musée Royaux des Beaux-Arts de Belgique, Brussels, Belgium*)



Closer Look



ivory scepter. The brazen-footed bulls puffed forth fire from their adamantine nostrils, and the grass burned at the touch of their breath. . . . Yet Jason faced them; with threatening look, they turned their awesome faces toward him as he came, their horns tipped with iron; with their cloven hooves they pounded the dusty earth and filled the place with their bellowing and clouds of smoke. The Argonauts were petrified with fear. On came Jason and felt not their fiery breath, so great was the power of [Medea's] drugs. He stroked their deep dew-laps with fearless hand and compelled them, driven beneath the yoke, to draw the plow's heavy weight and tear open the soil as yet unplowed. The Colchians were amazed, while the Argonauts shouted encouragement and strengthened Jason's spirits. (100–121)

10

Next he took the serpent's teeth in a bronze helmet and sowed them in the plowed field. The soil softened the seed, which had been smeared with strong poison, and the teeth grew and became new bodies. Just as a baby takes on human form in its mother's womb and inside its whole body grows in due proportion, only to issue into the outside world when it is fully formed, so, when the forms of men had been made in the womb of the pregnant earth, they rose from the mother-furrows, and, yet more miraculously, at their birth clashed their weapons. (121–130)

20

When the Greeks saw these warriors preparing to hurl their sharp spears at the head of the young Thessalian, their eyes and spirits were lowered by fear. Medea, too, who had made him safe from attack, grew pale when she saw so many enemies attacking the solitary young hero. . . . Jason threw a heavy rock into the middle of the enemy and turned their attack from himself to them: the earthborn brothers killed each other and fell in civil war. The Greeks applauded and eagerly embraced the victor. . . . (131–143)

It remained yet to put to sleep with drugs the wakeful serpent. It was the fearsome guardian of the golden tree, a monster with a crest, three tongues, and curved teeth. This serpent Aeson's heroic son fed with a soporific herb and repeated thrice a charm that brought peaceful sleep. When sleep came upon those eyes that it had not visited before, Jason took the gold, and in the pride of his spoils, took her who had made possible his success, a second prize. Victorious, he returned to the harbor of Iolcus with his wife. (149–158)

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The Return of the Argonauts

Pindar's Narrative

Ovid's narrative focuses on Jason the hero, winner not only of the fleece, the prize of his quest, but also of the princess Medea. He set sail with her, pursued by the Colchians under the leadership of Medea's brother, **Apsyrtus**, whom he killed in an ambush near the mouth of the Danube.⁶ Pindar gives the earliest continuous account of the capture of the fleece and the return journey. The poem is addressed to Arcesilas, king of Cyrene and winner of the chariot race at Delphi in 462 B.C.⁷ Pindar's narrative begins after Jason has successfully completed ploughing with the fire-breathing bulls (*Pythian Odes* 4. 239–254):

His companions stretched out their welcoming hands to the valiant hero, and they crowned him with garlands of grass and congratulated him with honeyed words. Then [Aeëtes] the wonderful child of the Sun told him of

the shining fleece, where the knives of Phrixus had stretched it out. And he did not expect that Jason would complete that labor. For the fleece lay in a thicket, the lair of a serpent, held in its fearsome jaws, and the serpent in thickness and length was greater than a fifty-oared ship which the blows of iron have built. . . . (239–246)

He killed the grey-eyed spotted serpent, O Arcesilas, and he stole Medea with her connivance, and she caused the death of Pelias. And they came to the waves of Oceanus and the Red Sea and the nation of the women of Lemnos, who had killed their men. And there they showed their strength in physical contests with clothing for the prize, and there they lay together. (249–254) 10

Pindar's narrative is brief and clear. Jason, as befits the hero of the quest, himself performed the final labor, took the prize, and returned home with the princess. Their journey took them to the ends of the earth (for the River of Ocean encircles the earth; see the map on p. 619) and to the mysterious but unspecified "Red Sea," which in Pindar's time usually meant the Indian Ocean. Earlier in the poem, Medea had referred to the journey during which "relying on my counsel we carried the sea-ship on our shoulders for twelve days, hauling it up from Ocean, across the desert lands" (4. 26–28). Although the twelve-day portage appears to have taken place in Africa, Pindar seems rather to be describing a voyage whose details are set in a mythological landscape (indicated by the River of Ocean beyond the boundaries of the world) than in any particular lands. Lemnos is a recognizable place in the Greek world, and Pindar places the Lemnian episode during the return. He adds the celebration of the **Lemnian Games**, which evidently were part of the funerary ritual in honor of the dead men of Lemnos, with a cloak as the appropriate prize for a festival that also marked the resumption of marriage.

Apollonius' Narrative and the Marriage of Jason and Medea

Apollonius of Rhodes took the Argonauts up the Danube, across to the head of the Adriatic, then up the mythical Eridanus River and across to the Rhone, down which they sailed to the Mediterranean Sea. Here they sailed to the western coast of Italy, where they visited Circe (the aunt of Medea), who purified Jason and Medea from the pollution caused by Jason's murder of Apsyrtus. After this, they encountered many of the same dangers described by Odysseus—the Planctae, Scylla and Charybdis, and the Sirens.

Next they came to the land of the Phaeacians, still pursued by the Colchians. Medea appealed to Queen Arete for protection, and she and the king, Alcinoüs, agreed not to give Medea up if she were already married to Jason. That night they celebrated the marriage, and the Colchians gave up their pursuit. Resuming their journey, the Argonauts sailed to Libya, where they were stranded on the shoals of the Syrtes. They carried the *Argo* on their shoulders to Lake Tritonis (a twelve-day journey), past the garden of the Hesperides. On the way Mopsus was killed by a snake. From the lake, they made their way back to the Mediterranean, guided by the sea-god Triton.⁸

Talus

Another adventure took place off the coast of Crete. The island was guarded by the bronze giant Talus, who walked around it three times a day and kept strangers from landing by throwing rocks at them. His life depended on a membrane (or bronze nail) that closed the entrance to a vein above one ankle. If this were opened, the ichor (the divine equivalent of human blood) would flow out and he would die. The Argonauts caused this to happen and thus Talus perished.⁹

The End of the Journey

Finally, the Argonauts reached Iolcus, and there the saga (like the epic of Apollonius) ends. Jason handed the fleece over to Pelias, and he dedicated the *Argo* to Poseidon at the Isthmus of Corinth. Years later, Jason was struck on the head and killed by a piece of timber from its stern that fell upon him.

The geographical details of the return of the Argonauts are confused and largely fanciful. The time when the saga was taking its final form (i.e., in the archaic period, before the sixth century) was one of expansion and discovery in the Greek world, when the Greeks traveled far to the east and west for trade and colonization, venturing as far as Russia and North Africa. The voyage of the *Argo* perhaps recalls actual voyages, but it is impossible to attempt to match details from Pindar and Apollonius with actual places.¹⁰

Jason and Medea in Greece

Iolcus

At Iolcus, Pelias refused to honor his pact with Jason, and Medea therefore contrived to cause his death. Making a display of her magic arts, Medea rejuvenated Jason's father, Aeson, by cutting him up and boiling him in a cauldron along with magic herbs, and then rejuvenated an old ram as well. Persuaded by these examples, the daughters of Pelias tried to rejuvenate their father in the same way. But Medea did not give them the magic herbs, and their attempt led only to Pelias' death.

Corinth

Thus, Jason was revenged on Pelias, but he did not gain the throne of Iolcus; for being defiled by the murder of Pelias, he and Medea were driven out of the city by Acastus, son of Pelias. They went to Corinth, the setting for Euripides' tragedy *Medea*. The connection between Medea and Corinth was made as early as the eighth century by the Corinthian poet Eumelos. In his version, Aeëtes and his brother Aloeus were the sons of Helios and Antiope. Helios divided his lands between the brothers, so that Aloeus inherited Arcadia and Aeëtes received "Ephyra," which Eumelos identified with Corinth. Aeëtes then went to Colchis, leaving Corinth in the hands of a regent. Later, the Corinthians summoned Medea from Iolcus to be their queen. Thus Jason became king of Corinth through his marriage with Medea, who meanwhile had resisted the advances of Zeus out of respect for Hera (who was especially worshiped at Corinth). As a reward, Hera promised to make Medea's children immortal.

Geography and Myth

It is tempting to try to trace the journeys of the heroes of saga: Odysseus and Jason are prime “tempters.” The map on p. 619 shows diagrammatically how Pindar’s contemporaries saw their world. Neither Pindar nor Apollonius can be used as a source for geographical identification: their world is one of the literary imagination, even though real places are named in their poems. Archaeologists, however, have shown that there is some basis for identifying Colchis with an area in modern Georgia, the territory that lies to the east of the Black Sea, occupied in antiquity by farmers and metalworkers at least since the third millennium B.C. (see map on p. 610). Greek trading settlements have been found dating from about 550 B.C., that is, about a century before Pindar’s poem. The mythological river Phasis is safely identified with the modern river Rioni, and the modern town of Vani was the most prosperous ancient city, corresponding to the mythical Colchis. Beyond these facts, and the fact that the area in Greek times was rich in gold, copper, and iron, there can be no certainty in making geographical identifications. The modern equivalent of gold is perhaps oil, for an oil pipeline has been built across Georgia from the Caspian coast of Azerbaijan to the Black Sea coast.

Medea therefore concealed her children in the sanctuary of Hera, believing that in this way she would make them immortal, but they died and were honored with a cult. Medea refers to this in her final speech to Jason in Euripides’ tragedy (*Medea* 1378–1383):

I shall bury them with my hand, carrying them into the sanctuary of Hera Akraia [Hera of the Acropolis], so that none of my enemies can violate them by digging up their graves. And I shall impose upon this land of Sisyphus [Corinth] a solemn feast and ritual for the future, in return for this impious murder.

The death of the children of Jason and Medea therefore was a central feature in the original myth.

Another variant, however, named **Creon** as king of Corinth and the enemy of Medea, who killed him and left her children in the sanctuary of Hera when she fled to Athens. The boys were killed by Creon’s family, who said that Medea had killed them. This version was the foundation of Euripides’ powerful drama, in which Jason and Medea lived in Corinth as exiles from Iolcus. Jason divorced Medea to marry **Glauce** (also called **Creusa**), the daughter of King Creon. In revenge, Medea sent her two children with a robe and a crown as wedding gifts to Glauce. The magic ointment with which Medea had smeared the gifts burned Glauce and Creon to death. After this, Medea killed her children as a final act of vengeance against Jason and escaped to Athens in a chariot drawn by winged dragons provided by her grandfather Helios. In the final scene of the drama, Medea appears in the chariot high above the stage holding the bodies of her murdered children, triumphing over Jason and foretelling his miserable end. Jason lived on at Corinth, and Medea was given asylum at Athens by King Aegeus. In the Additional Reading to this



Map of the World According to the Ideas of Hecataeus of Miletus (ca. 500 B.C.). The River of Ocean is assumed to run around the edge of the inhabited world, which is divided into Europe and Asia.
(© Laszlo Kubinji, 1994)

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chapter, we have added a summary of translations of important episodes from Euripides' *Medea* and commentary. From these, readers will be able to see for themselves how complex is the drama of Euripides and how disturbing are the issues that he raises.

Athens

While at Athens, Medea was said to have become the mother of Medus by Aegeus. Later, she nearly caused Aegeus to poison his son Theseus (see p. 592). Failing in this scheme, she fled from Athens to Persia, where Medus established the kingdom of Media. Medea herself eventually returned to Colchis, and the rest of her legend is lost in the ingenious fancies of individual authors.

Interpretations of the Saga

The Argonauts in Later Literature

The saga of Jason and the Argonauts has been filtered through literary interpretations as much as any other Greek saga.¹¹ It was known to Homer (who does not mention Medea), and it formed part of the epics of the eighth-century Corinthian poet Eumelos. In the third century B.C., it was the subject of the epic *Argonautica* of Apollonius of Rhodes, a work that was translated or adapted by more than one Roman epic poet. The unfinished *Argonautica* of Valerius Flaccus, dating from the second half of the first century A.D., includes much of Apollonius' narrative, to which Valerius added episodes of his own, including the rescue of Hesione by Hercules and Telamon (see p. 474). Statius, as we noted earlier, included a lengthy account of the legend of Hypsipyle in his *Thebaid*.

In drama, the *Medea* of Euripides has been a powerful influence, inspiring tragedies by Ovid (now lost), Seneca (which survives), and, in the twentieth century, Robinson Jeffers (*Medea*, 1946), to say nothing of many versions by French and German playwrights. It is one of the most frequently performed Greek tragedies in our contemporary theater. The saga appealed especially to the Victorians. William Morris' long narrative poem, *The Life and Death of Jason*, was published in 1867 and soon became popular. Its seventeen books cover the whole of Jason's saga, including the events in Corinth and his death. It owes as much, however, to Morris' feeling for medieval chivalry as to the classical epics, and Jason is a less ambiguous hero than he is in Apollonius or Euripides. Episodes from the saga were brilliantly narrated in Nathaniel Hawthorne's *Tanglewood Tales* (1853) and Charles Kingsley's *The Heroes* (1855). These versions were written with a strong moral bias toward courage and adventure, and they are, as Michael Grant has happily described them, "brisk, antiseptic narratives . . . jolly good hero-worshipping yarns, without esoteric overtones or significances."¹²



Medea, by Eduardo Paolozzi (1924–2005); welded aluminum, 1964, height 81 in. The machine parts threateningly imply the destructive power of the barbarian princess. The mythological title suggests an allegorical meaning for the work without precise narrative content. Paolozzi's use of mechanical parts can also be interpreted as a satire on the modern age of machines. (© Kröller-Müller Museum, Otterlo, The Netherlands)

The Hero's Quest

Jason's legend is better seen as a Quest using Propp's model. This view makes many of the folktale elements fall into a coherent structure. At the same time, much of the saga goes back to the earliest stages of Greek mythology, not excepting Medea, whose status as the granddaughter of the Sun must once have been more important than her functions as a magician. By far the most powerful interpretation of her part in the saga is the tragedy of Euripides, produced at Athens in 431 B.C. While Euripides concentrates on the psychology of Medea and

explores the tensions in her relations with Jason, he also makes Medea into a quasi-divine being in the final scene, as she leaves in the chariot of the Sun. Medea is older (in terms of the development of the myth) and grander than the romantic heroine of Apollonius and Valerius Flaccus, and more formal than the driven, deserted, and clever heroine of Euripides. She and many of the other leading characters in the saga have attributes that point to elements in the myth that are both earlier and more significant than the quasi-historical tale of adventure that it has become.

Additional Reading: Jason and Medea in Euripides

This summary of Euripides' *Medea* with commentary centers on a translation of the three scenes in which Jason and Medea appear together. Euripides begins with one of his typical prologues (cf. the *Hippolytus* and the *Bacchae* in Chapters 10 and 13)—a monologue that provides essential background and sets the scene for the tragedy to follow. The very first line that the Nurse utters



Medea Leaves Corinth in a Chariot Drawn by Dragons. Medea, wearing oriental cap and dress, drives a chariot sent by the Sun, whose rays encircle her. Winged Furies look down on the human figures below—on the left, Jason railing at Medea, and on the right the children's tutor and Medea's nurse mourning over the bodies of the two children, which are draped across an altar. A spotted feline reacts energetically to the dragons. The painting represents the final scene of Euripides' *Medea*. (Attributed to the Policoro Painter [South Italy, active 420–380 B.C.]. Lucanian Calyx-Krater, c. 400 B.C. Red-figure earthenware with added white, red, yellow, and brown wash; H. 50.5 cm. The Cleveland Museum of Art, Leonard C. Hanna Jr., Fund 1991.1)

is fraught with foreboding: “How I wish that the ship *Argo* had never winged its way between the dark Clashing Rocks into the land of the Colchians.” After they had come to Corinth, Jason and Medea and their two sons led a happy life, but now all is enmity between husband and wife. Jason has abandoned Medea and their children and has married Creusa (also called Glauce), daughter of Creon, king of Corinth. Medea is beside herself with anguish and rage, and the Nurse is terrified at the thought of what Medea might do; she even fears for the safety of the children, whom Medea has come to loathe because of their father. In the following scene between the Nurse and the Tutor, we learn further that Creon is about to exile both Medea and her children from the city. Medea enters, lamenting, crying out that she wants to die and eventually winning over the Chorus, women of Corinth, to her side by appealing to their common plight as women, which includes the virtual impossibility of finding a good husband. Her appeal, beginning with the words (215) “Women of Corinth,” is reminiscent of Phaedra’s to the women of Troezen in the *Hippolytus* and is equally laden with issues that belong to fifth-century Athens as much as to Mycenaean Greece.

Creon enters, and his first outcry is to order Medea and her children to leave Corinth at once and go into exile. He is afraid of Medea’s rage and her dire threats of terrible retaliation against the royal family, and, since he knows about her notorious skill in evil arts, he wants to assure, in particular, the safety of his daughter. In the exchange that follows, we witness Medea’s subtle guile, as she cleverly manipulates Creon to soften, with assurances of his safety; having been made sympathetic to her plight, he yields to her plea that she remain for only one day. In Robinson Jeffers’ paraphrase, Medea begs, “lend me this inch of time. . . .”¹³ What possible harm could this unfortunate woman do in such a brief period?

When Creon leaves, Medea confides in the Chorus with brutal frankness. She tells them that she would never have fawned upon this man, unless she were plotting revenge, and that he is a fool to have given her this one day to accomplish her revenge. She openly reveals some possible courses her actions might take to murder with impunity Creon himself, his daughter, and her husband.

The next scene presents the first encounter between Medea and Jason (446–626):



Audio

JASON: Now is not the first time but many times before I have seen your fierce temper and how it is an evil, impossible to cope with. You could have stayed in Corinth and kept your home, if only you had easily submitted to the decisions of those in power, but instead, because of your unreasonable arguments you will be exiled from this land. It doesn’t matter to me. Go on forever, if you like, telling everyone that Jason is the vilest of men. But for what you have said against the ruling family, consider it pure luck that you are being punished only with exile. I, to be sure, have always tried to assuage the fury of the outraged king, but you never give up your stupidity, with your continual abuse of the royal family. And so you will be thrown out of this land. (446–458)

Nevertheless, even after all this, I have not disowned those dear to me, and I have come to provide for your well-being, woman, so that you will not go into exile with the children, penniless and in need of anything. Exile brings in its train many hardships, and indeed even if you hate me, I would not be able to think badly of you, ever. (459–464)

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MEDEA: O most vile human being in every way. These are the worst words that I can find with which to accost you verbally for your lack of manliness. You have come to me, you have come, even though you are most hateful to the gods, and not only to me and the entire human race. This is not courage nor even audacity to do wrong to dear ones and then look them in the face— 20 this is shamelessness, a disease, the greatest of all the vices among human beings. Yet you did well to come here, for after I have told you how evil you are, my soul will be lightened and you will suffer pain because of what you hear. (465–474)

From first things first I will begin what I have to say. I saved you, as all the Greeks know who embarked with you on the ship *Argo*, when you were sent to master the fire-breathing bulls with yokes and sow the death-bringing field. I killed the serpent, which unsleeping guarded the golden fleece, twining its many coils around it, and brought you the light of salvation. I myself betrayed my father and my home and came to Iolcus, below Mt. Pelion, with you, I too 30 much in love but not too wise. And I murdered Pelias at the hands of his own daughters, in a most dreadful way to die, and ruined his home. After benefiting from all these things that I did, you, vilest of men, have betrayed me. You have taken a new wife, although children had been born to us. Indeed, if you were still childless, you might have been forgiven for desiring this second marriage. No more is there trust in your oaths to me. I am not able to discern whether you think the gods you swore by then no longer still rule or that new divine ordinances are now to be followed among human beings, since you know full well that you have not been true to what you swore to me. Oh, my poor right hand, which you clasped so many times and my poor knees, how 40 they were clutched for nothing by a base man, and how I have been cheated of my hopes. (475–498)

Still I will share my dilemma with you as though you were a friend. What helpful solution can I expect from you? Nevertheless, I will do so, for having been asked what I should do, you will appear all the more vile. Where can I turn now? To the house of my father which I betrayed for you by coming to your fatherland or to the wretched daughters of Pelias? A fine reception I would receive in their home, I who killed their father. And so this is my predicament. I have made my loved ones at home hate me and, because of what I did for you, I have made enemies of those whom I should never have 50 wronged. As a reward for these services, you have made me so happy, I am sure, in the eyes of many women. In you I possess an amazing and trustworthy husband, if I am thrown out of this land and wander an exile bereft of friends, with my children, alone and abandoned. A fine reproach for a newly married bridegroom that his children wander as beggars and I do too, the one who saved you. (499–515)

O Zeus, who gave to human beings sure signs for gold that is counterfeit, why is there no birthmark stamped on the skin by which one must recognize the man who is base?

CHORUS: Terrible is the rage and very difficult to heal, when loved ones battle 60 it out. (520–521)

JASON: I must, as it seems, not be a bad speaker but just like a trusty captain of a ship reef up the sails and ride out from under the stormy verbiage of your busy tongue. While you exaggerate excessively your kindness to me, I consider Aphrodite alone of gods and mortals to be the savior of

my expedition. You do have a clever mind, but it would be invidious to go through the story of how Eros with his unerring arrows compelled you to save my life. But I will not go into the many details. Where you did help me, however, you got more in return for my safety than you gave, as I will explain. First, you dwell in the land of Hellas instead of a barbarian country and you experience justice and the exercise of laws, without the mere gratification of force. All Hellenes have come to know that you are wise and you have gained a reputation. But if you were still living at the very end of the earth, you would be of no account. I would rather have the good fortune of an outstanding reputation than a house full of gold or the power to sing a more beautiful song than Orpheus. (522–544) 70

So much then I say to you about my labors. After all, you started this contest of words. With respect to your reproaches against me concerning my marriage into royalty, I will prove to you that in this first of all I was wise, next that I was not driven by sex, and finally that I acted as a great friend to you and to my sons. 80

Now, now, Medea, be quiet. (550)

After I moved here from the land of Iolcus, bringing with me the burden of many hopeless misfortunes, what luckier find could I have come upon than this: to marry the daughter of the king, even though I was an exile. It was not that I loathed your bed, your accusation that so galls you, and I was not anxious to outrival those who have many children. The ones I have are enough and I have no complaint. But my purpose was to insure that we should live well, this is of the greatest importance, and not be in want, knowing full well that every one takes pains to avoid a friend who is poor. Also I wanted to bring up my children in a manner that was worthy of my house and to father brothers and sisters for the children born of you. I wanted to treat them all alike and, having established one unified family, I would be blessed with happiness. For you, why is there need of children? For me, it is profitable to benefit the ones I already have by means of those whom I hope will be born. I haven't planned badly, have I? Even you would agree, if only the marriage and matter of sex did not gall you so. You women think everything depends on sex! If any trouble happens on that score, you turn the best laid, finest plans into causes for hostility. Men ought to be able to beget children from some other source and the female gender should not exist. Then evil would not exist for human beings. (551–575) 90 100

CHORUS: Jason, you have made your arguments look good but, nevertheless, to me, even if I am speaking against your point of view, you seem not to act justly in betraying your wife.

MEDEA: To be sure, I am at odds with many people about many things. For to me the man who is unjust and born a clever speaker incurs the heaviest retribution, because overly confident that he can cover up his wrongs beautifully, he stops at nothing in his tongue-wagging arguments. But he is not as clever as all that. And so it is with you. Do not now become a specious liar and a devastating talker against me, for one word will lay you out. If you were not a coward, you should have persuaded me to agree before making this marriage, but not without saying a thing to your loved ones. (579–587) 110

JASON: You would have given me splendid support, I imagine, if I had told you about the marriage, you, who not even now can bring yourself to abandon your overwhelming rage.

MEDEA: It was not this consideration that controlled your behavior, but rather you thought that as you grew older a foreign marriage was likely to end badly.

JASON: You can be sure of this: it was not on account of a woman that I made this marriage with the daughter of a king, to which I am committed but, just as I said before, it was because of my wish to save you and to beget royal children as brothers and sisters to my own children, a bulwark for our family. 120

MEDEA: I do not wish to have a life of good fortune that causes pain nor a prosperity that galls my heart. (598–599)

JASON: Do you not know how you must change your wish to show yourself the wiser? Wish that your best interests not appear painful and that you do not think that you are unfortunate when you are fortunate.

MEDEA: Continue with your hubris, since there is a refuge for you, but I will go from this land, an abandoned exile.

JASON: You choose this yourself. Don't blame anyone else. (605)

MEDEA: What did I do? I didn't take a wife and betray you. 130

JASON: You uttered unholy curses against the royal house.

MEDEA: Yes, and I am a curse to your house too.

JASON: I will not debate the matter any further, but if you want to accept any financial help for the children and yourself in your exile, say so. Know that I am ready to give with an ungrudging hand and to send introductions to my friends who will treat you well. You are crazy not to want to accept these offers, woman. If you forget your rage, you will have the more to gain. (609–615)

MEDEA: I would never use the help of your friends, and I would not accept anything from you, so don't give me anything. For gifts from an evil man hold no benefit. 140

JASON: Well then, I call the gods as witnesses that I want to do everything for you and the children. What is good for you isn't to your liking but you push away your friends by your audacity. Therefore you suffer all the more. (619–622)

MEDEA: Go, for you must be possessed by longing for your newly won girl, being so long away from the palace. Play your role as bridegroom; perhaps—and with god's help I will say this—you have made such a marriage that will end up to your grief. (623–629)

Within the framework of a heroic myth, we witness a mundane and frighteningly real confrontation between a man and a woman, husband and wife, once a marriage is over. It is difficult to sympathize with Jason, arrogant and cold, who immediately takes the stance of the tolerant and benevolent provider, even though it is Medea, he claims, who is in the wrong. It is true, as we have learned from Creon himself, that Medea's rage and deadly threats against the royal family have been the reasons for her exile, but, in Medea's view, no other recourse is possible except vengeance against her enemies. When Medea lists her services to Jason, including betrayal of her family and country, murder, and even the slaying of the dragon, the eternal question immediately arises: should the continuation of a marriage be based upon debts from the past? Her appeal to earlier pledges and oaths perhaps has a greater religious and moral authority. It seems that her foreign marriage with Jason holds no legal validity for Jason in Corinth.

When Jason lists the blessings that he has conferred upon Medea in return, he presents us with one of the many fascinating issues raised by the play. He

boasts that he has brought Medea to a system of justice in an enlightened land, far superior to that of her own barbarian country, where brute force is the rule. For Medea, no justice at all exists in a land where she can be treated with such injustice, and vengeful violence represents to her an earlier and better standard of morality.

One of the most heartless responses to Medea is Jason's claim that she had no choice in her actions; all that she did for him she did under the compulsion of an overwhelming love, inspired by Aphrodite and Eros. He never mentions any kind of affection that he might have once held for her. It is most rewarding to read the *Argonautica* of Apollonius of Rhodes for his version of the events in Colchis and the beginnings of the relationship between Jason and Medea. In Book 3, Apollonius draws a justly admired portrait of Medea as a woman smitten by love, and he seems to take his cue from these lines of Jason in Euripides. When Medea, at the court of Aeëtes, first set eyes on Jason, an invisible Eros, crouched low at Jason's feet, shoots an arrow directly at Medea, and she is consumed with the flame of passion. Eventually, though, Jason too is touched by feelings of love.

In Euripides, Jason's rhetoric is that of the exemplary sophist, one who by clever and devious arguments can make or try to make the worse cause seem the better. To Medea, all his words are specious and insincere, designed to disguise the fact that he is a base and cowardly man and his actions despicable. But at least some of his arguments may be true and very understandable, however morally dubious and unforgivable. Despite all of Medea's help, Jason did not realize his ultimate goal, to become the king of Iolcus. The murder of Pelias, orchestrated by Medea, failed in its purpose, and Jason had to flee with Medea to Corinth. Now with his days of glory past, his shattered hopes inspire a desperate ambition. As he explains, his marriage into the royal family is calculated and pragmatic, his golden opportunity, a last chance for power and success. Less credible may be his contentions that his actions are not motivated by passion (the beautiful young princess holds no sexual attraction for him) and that his plans were designed to help Medea and the children; yet, apparently he had not expected them to be exiled, and perhaps he did have in mind a prosperous future in which they might be included. Medea is not above sophistry herself: she claims that Jason has left them destitute, while at the same time refusing to accept the liberal help that he offers.

To continue with Euripides, Aegeus, the king of Athens, arrives in Corinth (a lucky coincidence that does not seem too contrived in the momentum of performance). He has been to the oracle of Apollo at Delphi to inquire about a cure for his inability to beget children and is on his way to consult with Pittheus, king of Troezen, about the response before he returns home. Medea tells Aegeus about her husband's cruel betrayal and her imminent exile and makes him feel pity toward her plight and critical of Jason's behavior. She begs Aegeus to receive her into his house in Athens as a suppliant, never to give her over to her enemies in pursuit, and she in return will, through her knowledge of medicines, cure him of his childlessness.¹⁴ Aegeus agrees to this exchange of favors first because of the gods (her salvation is a just cause) and then because of her benefit to him. Medea, however, must leave Corinth by her own devices because Aegeus as a guest there does not want to offend his hosts by interfering. If Medea does reach Athens, Aegeus promises to protect her, since he is a just king. At Medea's

insistence, he swears a solemn oath by Earth, the sacred light of Helios, and all the gods that he will do what he has promised.

Once again Medea has duped a king. Now she has made her escape secure, eliciting a safe refuge from Aegeus, who is ignorant of what she is planning to do. It may be that Euripides ironically depicts his Athens, so renowned in myth and drama for being a righteous champion of the oppressed, as the deceived protector of a murderer, whose victims include her own children.

Medea now exults before the Chorus, calling upon Zeus, the justice of Zeus, and the light of the Sun in her victory over her enemies. She goes on boldly to reveal fully the exact details of her plans for what she in actual fact will accomplish. The laughter of one's enemies is intolerable; they must pay. We learn as well, amidst her anguished groans, her chilling decision to kill her children. Has the realization of Aegeus' desperation over his childlessness steeled her for the decision to commit this atrocity? Jason, with god's help, will never see alive his children born by her, and he will never have other children by his new bride. Medea claims she would never want to be considered weak, passive, or base. No, just the opposite, she, like those whose life is most renowned, is hurtful to enemies and kindly to friends. Among her enemies now, it seems, are her children by Jason. And so she begins her plans for destruction by sending the Nurse to summon Jason, and she artfully feigns reconciliation in this second scene between the two of them (866–975):

JASON: I have come at your command. For even though you bear ill will, I would still not fail to come, but I will hear you out. What is it now that you want from me, woman? (866–868)

MEDEA: Jason, I beg you to forgive what I have said. It is only fair that you bear with my rages now, since many have been the acts of love between us in the past. I have argued the case with myself and am full of self-reproach. "Stubborn fool, why am I so insane and hostile to those who are making good plans, and why do I persist in my enmity against the rulers of this land and against my husband, who is doing for us what is most advantageous by marrying a princess and begetting children who will be as brothers and sisters to my own? Will I not cease from my anger? What is wrong with me? The gods are providing for me well. I have children and I know that we are being exiled from this land and are in need of friends." I mulled over these considerations and realized my great lack of foresight and my useless rage. And so now I applaud and think that you are most wise and reasonable to take on this marriage for us. I am the foolish one. I ought to share in your plans, join you in carrying them out, stand by our nuptial bed, and take joy in my support of your marriage. But we women are what we are, I don't say evil, but just women. You should not imitate our nature or respond to our childishness with childishness. I give in and admit that I was not thinking right then, but now I have come to a better understanding of this situation. (869–893)

O children, children, here, come out of the house, come out. Embrace your father, greet your father with me, and along with your mother be reconciled and turn from our former enmity against a loved one. We have made peace and our anger has given way. Take his right hand. Alas for me when I think about any of the possible hidden misfortunes in store. O my children, will you stretch out your dear hands so, throughout a long life? Poor me, how prone to weep and

full of fear. Now that I have at long last ended the quarrel with your father, I have drenched your tender faces with my tears. (894–905)

CHORUS: Fresh tears have started in my eyes too. May the present evil not proceed any further and increase. 30

JASON: I approve, woman, of all this and I do not blame your former hostility. It is to be expected that women become enraged when a husband secretly makes a deal for a marriage of a different sort. But your heart has changed for the better, and you have come to recognize the winning plan. This is the behavior of a reasonable woman. (908–913)

For you, children, your father, thoughtful and concerned, has provided great security, with the help of the gods. For I believe that you with your new brothers and sisters will be foremost in this land of Corinth in time to come. Only you must grow to manhood. Both your father and whatever god is kindly will take care of the rest. May I see you coming to young manhood, strong and victorious over my enemies. 40

You there, Medea, moist with fresh tears. Why do you turn away, so pale? Why are you not happy to hear what I have been saying?

MEDEA: It is nothing. I was thinking about these children here. (925)

JASON: Bear up now, for I will take care of them.

MEDEA: I will bear up. I will not distrust your words, but a woman is by nature feminine and prone to tears.

JASON: Why, then, do you cry over these children too much?

MEDEA: I gave birth to them. When you prayed that the children might live, I wondered if this would happen and pity overwhelmed me. (930–931) 50

But I have told you only some of the reasons for you having to come to talk to me, and now I will mention the others. Since the rulers of this land have decided to banish me, this is the best thing for me too, I know full well, not to live here and be in your way or theirs since I seem to be a menace to the royal house. I, for my part, am resigned to go into exile, but the children, beg Creon that they not be exiled too so that they may be brought up by your hand. (932–940)

JASON: I don't know if I can persuade him, but I will try.

MEDEA: Then you beg your wife to ask her father not to exile the children. 60

JASON: Certainly, I'll do it and I think I will persuade her. (944)

MEDEA: If she is a woman like the rest, you will, and I will help you in this. I will send her gifts, which I know are by far the most beautiful of any on this earth today, an exquisite robe and a diadem of gold, and the children will bring them. But one of the servants here must bring them out as quickly as possible. Your bride will be blessed by happiness forever, since she has found you, the best of men, to be her husband and been given this treasure, which Helius, father of my father, gave to his descendants. (945–955)

Take these bridal gifts, children, into your hands, carry them, and give them to the princess, the happy bride. Certainly she will accept these gifts with which she can find no fault. 70

JASON: O foolish woman, why do you empty your hands of these things? Do you think the royal household is in need of fine robes, or gold; do you really think so? Keep these things; do not give them away. For if my wife prizes me at all, she will prefer to oblige me rather than accept treasures, I am quite sure. (959–963)

MEDEA: No, you must not dissuade me. They say gifts persuade even the gods and for mortals gold is more powerful than a thousand words. Divine luck is hers; now god blesses her good fortune. She is young and a princess. I would give my life and not only gold to repeal the exile of my children. 80
(964–968)

But children, when you both have entered the rich palace, entreat the new bride of your father, my mistress, and beg her that you not be banished from this land. Give her these treasures and, most important of all, she must accept these gifts into her own hand. (909–973)

So go quickly as possible! May you succeed and come back to your mother, good messengers of what she is longing to hear.

Pompous Jason is fooled by obsequious flattery into believing Medea has accepted the wisdom of his actions. She fully understands how to play upon the foibles of his character and make him completely blind to the treachery in hers, which he fails even to suspect despite his knowledge of their past. The scene



Medea Murders Her Son.

Campanian red-figure amphora by the Ixion painter, ca. 325 B.C. Only one of Medea's sons is shown in this scene, as she thrusts her sword a second time into his body, which is already bleeding. He stretches out his arm, pleading for mercy in vain. The scene is set in a temple; on the right, on a column above the altar is a small statue of a god, perhaps Apollo. (Erich Lessing/*Art Resource*, NY)

confirms Jason's love for his sons, and there is an ominous irony in Medea's tears, which he does not understand.

There follows a terrifying scene between Medea and her blameless children, exposing her pain and agonized indecision in the face of their loving tenderness. Then comes the return of the messenger from the palace who describes for an exultant Medea, relishing every exquisite detail, the horrifying deaths of the bride Creusa and her father Creon. Convinced by Jason, the princess accepted the beautiful gifts from the children. As the poisoned robe and diadem consumed her, her father rushed to save her but he became fused in her struggles to escape and they died in agony together. With this news of her success, Medea decides with finality that her children (who will be killed anyway, she assumes, because of what she has done) must die by her own hand. We hear their piteous cries from within, as Medea kills them with a sword.

Upon the deaths of Creusa and Creon, Jason rushes to confront Medea and the play ends with this final confrontation (1293–1414):



Audio

JASON: You women standing near the door, is she still inside the house, Medea, the one who has done such terrible things, or has she made her escape in flight? To be sure, she will have to hide in the depths of the earth or soar aloft on wings to the heavens above, if she is to avoid paying retribution to the royal house. Does she imagine that she will flee from here unpunished for having killed the sovereigns of this land? Still I am not as concerned about her as I am about my children. Those whom she has wronged will take care of her punishment, but I have come to save the life of my sons so that the next of kin may do them no harm by exacting vengeance for the unholy crime committed by their mother. (1293–1305)

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CHORUS: Jason, poor man, if you knew the depths of your misfortune, you would not have spoken these words.

JASON: What do you mean? Can it be that she wants to kill me too?

CHORUS: Your children are dead, murdered by their mother.

JASON: Woe is me! What are you saying? Woman, how you have destroyed me. (1310)

CHORUS: You must understand that your children are no longer alive.

JASON: Where has she killed them, within the house or outside?

CHORUS: Open the doors and you will see the slaughter of your sons.

JASON: Quickly, servants, unlock the doors and open them up so that I may see this two-fold evil, my dead sons and her, their killer, whom I will kill in just retribution. (1314–1316)

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MEDEA: Why do you rush at the doors and attempt to unlock them in order to find the corpses and their murderer? Stop your efforts. If there is anything you want of me, say what it is that you wish, but you will never be able to touch me. Helius, the father of my father, has given me this chariot, a defense against the hand of an enemy. (1317–1322)

JASON: O hatred personified, most detestable abomination to the gods, to me, and to the whole race of human beings. You who gave them birth brought yourself to drive a sword into your own children and kill them and destroy me too by making me childless. Having done this, you still look upon the sun and the earth, even though you dared this most impious deed. May you die! Now I am sane; but then I was insane when I brought you out of a barbarian land

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from your house to a home among the Hellenes, you, a great evil, the betrayer of your father and the country that nourished you. The gods have brought down upon me the avenging spirit that should have been meant for you, for it was you who killed your brother at the hearth before you even set foot on the *Argo*, my ship with its beautiful prow. You began with actions like these. Now after you had married a man like me and borne me children, you murdered them because of sex and jealousy. There are no women in Hellas who would ever dare such a thing. Instead of one of them, I preferred to marry you, a hateful union and ruinous for me, you, a lioness, not a woman, more savage in nature than Scylla in her Tuscan waters. But I would not be able to sting you, however endless my reproaches, since you have such an inbred brazen hostility. Go to perdition, evil-doer, child-killer! All I have left is to bewail my ill-fate. (1323–1347) 40

From my new bride and marriage I will not derive any joy and benefit, and as for my boys whom I raised, I will not be able to speak to them again alive but I have lost them.

MEDEA: I would have gone on at length to respond to these words of yours, if Zeus, the father, did not understand what I did for you and what you did to me. You were not about to spend a happy life laughing at me after you had dishonored our bed, nor were the princess and Creon, who gave her to you in marriage, about to throw me out of this land, with impunity. And so call me a lioness if you wish and Scylla who lives in the Tuscan sea. I have stung you in the heart, as I had to do. (1351–1360) 50

JASON: You yourself also feel the pain and share in my misfortune.

MEDEA: Only too true, but the pain is soothed if you cannot laugh at me.

JASON: O my children, fated with such a wicked mother!

MEDEA: O my sons, you were destroyed by your father's sick treachery!

JASON: Now then, it was not my hand that killed them. (1365) 60

MEDEA: No, it was your hubris and your newly arranged marriage.

JASON: Do you really believe it right to kill them, just because of a marriage?

MEDEA: Do you really think that this painful insult is trivial to your wife?

JASON: To a wife who is sensible, but to you everything is vile.

MEDEA: These children are no more. This will sting you. (1370)

JASON: These children are alive, alas, spirits of vengeance down upon your head.

MEDEA: The gods know who began this suffering.

JASON: They know, to be sure, your hateful mind and heart.

MEDEA: Go ahead and hate! I loathe your bitter, barking voice. 70

JASON: As I do yours. Our separation is only too easy. (1375)

MEDEA: How so? What shall I do? For I too want it desperately.

JASON: Let me bury these corpses and mourn over them.

MEDEA: Certainly not! I will bury them by my own hand, bringing them to the sanctuary of Hera Akraia in Corinth, so that no one of my enemies will violate their graves by tearing them up. In this Corinthian land of Sisyphus, I will institute a holy festival and religious rites forevermore, in expiation for this impious murder. I myself will go to Athens in the land of Erechtheus to live with Aegeus, son of Pandion. But you, as is fitting for a base coward, will die an unheroic death, struck on the head by a piece of your *Argo*, having witnessed the bitter end of my marriage to you. (1378–1388) 80

JASON: May the avenging Fury of the murdered children destroy you, and also Justice, avenger of blood-guilt.

MEDEA: What god or divine spirit will hear you, false liar, and betrayer of oaths.
 JASON: Oh, alas, you polluted murderess of children!
 MEDEA: Go home and bury your wife.
 JASON: I am going, bereft of my two sons. (1395)
 MEDEA: Your mourning has not really begun yet; old age is left for you to grieve.
 JASON: O children, so very dear!
 MEDEA: To their mother, not you. 90
 JASON: And yet you killed them.
 MEDEA: Yes, to cause you pain.
 JASON: Oh, poor wretch that I am, how I long to embrace my children and kiss their dear lips. (1399–1400)
 MEDEA: Now you speak to them, now you greet them with love, before you rejected them.
 JASON: By the gods, let me touch the soft and gentle bodies of my sons.
 MEDEA: That is impossible. You ask in vain.
 JASON: Zeus, do you hear all this? How I am driven away, the treatment I suffer from this polluted, child-slaying lioness. But insofar as I have the power and am able, I offer up my lament and call upon the gods to witness how you 100
 killed my sons and prevented me from touching them and burying their bodies. How I wish that I had never begotten them to see them dead by your hand. (1405–1414)

Jason approved when Medea killed more than once on his behalf; now true recognition has come at last (but too late) that she is a murderess. For Medea, her hatred of Jason and the compulsion to cause him the ultimate pain are more powerful than her love for her children and her own suffering wrought by their murder. How unbearable for us is the slaughter of sweet, young innocence to satisfy cruel, selfish, and ruthless passions. Both Medea and Jason are responsible for the tragedy, but Medea's claim that Jason, not she, is the real perpetrator must surely be the ultimate sophistry of all! In this horrifying denouement, Euripides' masterful use of the *deus ex machina* illuminates the profundity of his art. It is Medea herself who acts as the *deus ex machina*, the protagonist integral to the whole plot who provides its resolution from without (not unlike Dionysus in the *Bacchae*). When Medea appears untouchable, above Jason in the chariot sent by her grandfather Helios, she becomes transformed and takes on the attributes of a primordial deity who has with divine impunity meted out the cruel and terrible vendetta of an older order of justice.

No other play illustrates more succinctly how our reactions to a work of art are inevitably determined by who we are, what we believe, and what we have experienced. Its ruthless delineation of character and motivation and the relentless power of its emotional and cathartic impact never fail to elicit the most conflicting judgments and vehement interpretations; the arguments will surely go on forever.

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Primary Sources

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Euripides	<i>Medea</i> (selections)
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 7.100–158
Pindar	<i>Pythian Ode</i> 4.184–187, 239–254

Additional Sources

Apollonius of Rhodes	<i>Argonautica</i>
Seneca	<i>Medea</i>
Valerius Flaccus	<i>Argonautica</i>

Notes

1. Sources for the saga are the Greek epic *Argonautica* by Apollonius of Rhodes (third century B.C.) and the Latin epic *Argonautica* by Valerius Flaccus (late first century A.D.). Pindar's complex fourth *Nemean Ode* (ca. 460 B.C.) is the most poetic account, and Ovid (early first century A.D.) has a brief narrative in Book 7 of the *Metamorphoses*. Graham Anderson, *Fairytale in the Ancient World* (London: Routledge, 2000), pp. 72–82, analyzes the fairytale motifs in the story.
2. Her name is also given as Alcimede or Amphinome.
3. He was the son of Poseidon and the husband of Cleopatra, daughter of Boreas. Different reasons are given for his blindness.
4. Clashing rocks called *Planctae* (Wanderers) appear in the Argonauts' return voyage and in the *Odyssey*. Herodotus calls them *Cyaneae* (Dark-rocks).
5. The teeth came from the Theban serpent killed by Cadmus and had been given to Aeëtes by Athena.
6. Apollodorus has Medea take Apsyrtus on the *Argo* and delay the pursuers by cutting him up and throwing his limbs piecemeal into the sea.
7. The earliest epic narratives of the saga were part of the *Corinthiaka* and *Naupaktika* of the Corinthian poet Eumelos (ca. 730 B.C.). Only a few lines survive.
8. Triton gave a clod of earth to the Argonaut Euphemus as a token that his descendants would rule in Libya. From it grew the island of Thera, from which eventually the Greek colony of Cyrene was founded in Libya by the descendants of Euphemus.
9. There are many different accounts of the origin, functions, and death of Talus.
10. See Janet R. Bacon, *The Voyage of the Argo* (London: Methuen, 1925), Chapter 9. For yet another attempt to retrace the journey, see T. Severin, *The Jason Voyage: The Quest for the Golden Fleece* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1985).
11. For a discussion of some literary and artistic interpretations, see James J. Clauss and Sarah Iles Johnston, eds., *Medea: Essays on Medea in Myth, Literature, Philosophy, and Art* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1997).

12. Michael Grant, *Myths of the Greeks and Romans* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1962; New York: Mentor Books, 1964), p. 302 of the London edition. A modern verse epic is by John Gardner, *Jason and Medeia* (New York: Knopf, 1973).
13. Robinson Jeffers, *Medea* (New York: Random House, 1946), p. 25.
14. For the problem in reconciling the oracle received by Aegeus with Medea's promise to cure him of childlessness, see p. 590 with note 14, on p. 605.

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PART THREE

The Nature of Roman Mythology



Jacques-Louis David, *The Oath of the Horatii*